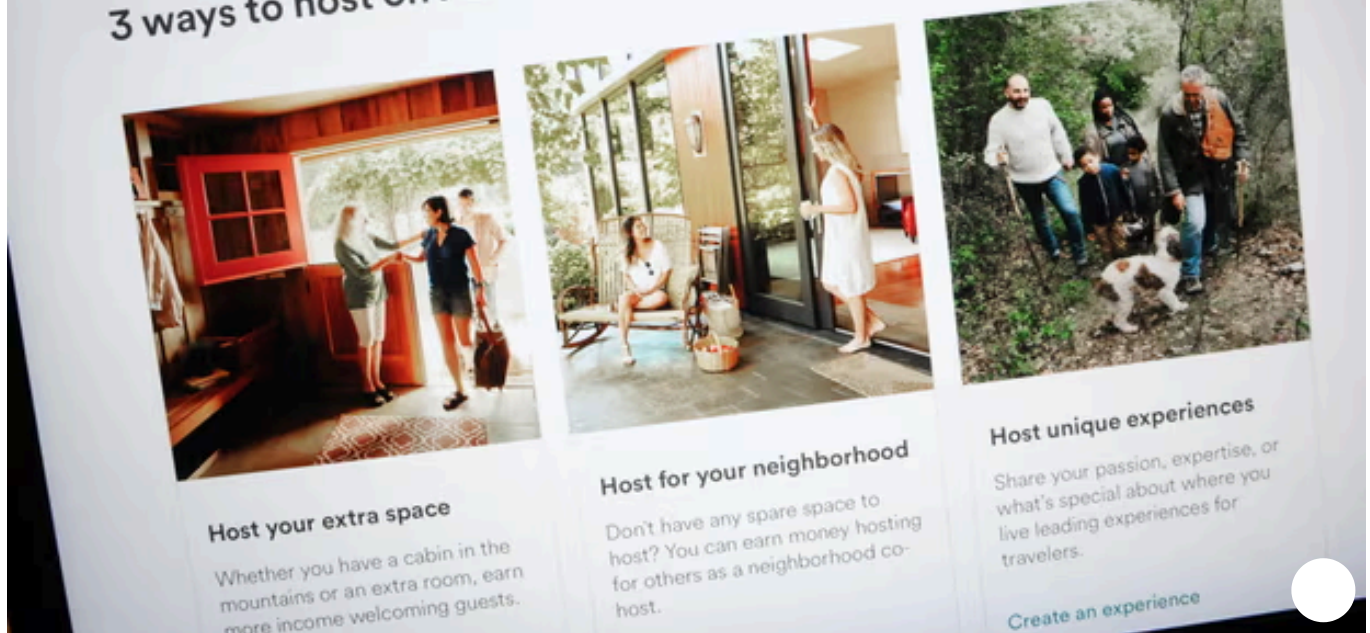




## Your problems, with Anna Tims

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# Airbnb is in denial over concerns we raised about our host

He had been struck off the medical register and we feared the apartment might have been fitted with cameras



**Anna Tims**

Wed 31 May 2023 09.30 BST

I booked an **Airbnb** flat in London for my wife and two daughters. I later discovered that the host has been struck off the medical register for inappropriate sexual conduct, and I am worried that the apartment may be fitted with cameras.

Airbnb, although agreeing that it is far from ideal, will only refund half the rent because it is upholding the host's cancellation policy.

It's not the money that is the issue here, it's Airbnb's complete denial of any responsibility.

**JM, Edinburgh**

This is a painful case for a number of reasons. The host, a former hospital doctor, was struck off in 2018 after a tribunal found he had waged a nine-day campaign of harassment against a junior medic.

Given this background, the guided tour of the rental apartment, which the host has filmed for guests, is unnerving. The place is fully wired up with technical wizardry, and you're worried that among the sensors screwed to the ceilings there may be cameras.

The skimpily clad host even disconcertingly emphasises that a sensor in the bathroom is not a camera. "I'm not looking at what you're doing in the bathroom," he says.

Given that the videos he sent his victim were filmed in his shower, this did not reassure you.

To be clear, the host was not convicted of an offence in a criminal court. There's no evidence that the flat does contain cameras and, according to Airbnb, guest reviews have been positive.

However, your concerns are understandable. So understandable that an Airbnb agent wrote that, as the mother of a daughter herself, she could "understand where you're coming from", while informing you that the host's cancellation policy applies. She apologised for the "inconvenience" this caused you.

It's alarming that Airbnb's cancellation policy trumps potential safeguarding concerns. The personal character of a host is not included in its list of extenuating circumstances for cancellation, and Airbnb's published eligibility criteria only withholds accounts from underage users, or those with affiliations to extremist organisations.

I asked the company what its policy is if a host is found to have a criminal record, and what investigations are undertaken if a guest raises a safety issue about a host or a property.

Airbnb tells me safety is its priority and that any concerns are investigated. It says the handling of your complaint is being reviewed.

It claims that it bans account holders with convictions that might compromise guests' safety. However, the link it provides is to a policy that applies only in the US. It says: "We have contacted the guest to provide a full refund, as well as rebooking support, and we are removing the host from the platform."

You have received a full refund.

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